kiln’. Abu’l Fazl, by Badauni’s own admission, ‘worked so strenuously at the dagh-u-mhali (branding) business that he managed by his intelligence and time-serving qualities to raise himself to a mansab of 2,000 and the dignity of a Wazir’. As for Badauni, he would be shackled by something much more intangible— his own obduracy and a certain fatal stubbornness. But in 1575, both the men were eager, interested participants in the discussions at the ibadat khana, proud of their massive erudition and keen to display their wit and sharply incisive thinking.

The most important members of the ulema at this time were Shaikh Abd un-Nabi, and Abdullah Sultanpuri. For a long while, the young Padshah had been especially solicitous and respectful of the older theologian, Abd un-Nabi. Akbar would visit the sadr, and stand barefoot before him to listen to his lectures on the traditions of the Prophet. He would bring the sadr his shoes as an act of devotion and place them before the shaikh’s feet. But most of these theologians, as pointed out by historian John F. Richards, ‘were neither speculative intellectuals nor serious religious thinkers’. Abd un-Nabi, in particular, was abrasive and rude. On one occasion, when the Padshah presented himself on a Friday to listen to the sadr’s lectures, Abd un-Nabi grew infuriated because Akbar was wearing yellow, considered to be against the sharia. The sadr furiously rebuked the Padshah and even threw his staff at him, offending him deeply. The distressed young Padshah did not react but later went to complain to his mother, Hamida Banu, about the appalling behaviour of the sadr. Abd un-Nabi also took satisfaction in humiliating the great amirs of the court. He would sit down after midday prayers, wash his hands and feet and, while carrying out his ablutions, spit on the faces and clothes of assembled courtiers, feigning inadvertence. Moreover, though the office of the sadr was that of the highest religious dignitary in the land, it was attached to other duties, such as the distribution of royal charities, making the position open to corruption. Even Badauni admitted that the shaikh had become insufferably arrogant in his habits, dealing with people in an ’infamous manner’, because of the power he commanded as sadr towards those who came asking for patronage. As for Abdullah Sultanpuri, it was discovered that he too was corrupt and avoided paying the obligatory charitable tax on property by transferring his assets to his wife’s name every year when the time for tax inspection came around. Moreover, these two men were ‘at loggerheads with each other, and had